

Chapter 20-1

It took Liang Shi quite a while to get her heart beating at a normal rhythm again.

As soon as she reached the entrance, Xu Qingya gave her an ambiguous look, accompanied by two "tsk tsk" sounds.

Somewhat sarcastic and ironic.

Though it carried a teasing element.

It made Liang Shi quite embarrassed.

It felt a bit like back in school when you got slightly close to a boy, everyone would whistle or give you playful looks.

Back then she only felt awkward, but this time there was also a hint of... small joy.

She categorized this emotion as—everyone wants to get close to beautiful women, that kind of pleasure.

Liang Shi flipped open the metal cover of the combination lock, entered the villa's passcode, then stepped aside to let the Xu sisters enter first.

Xu Qingya was quite familiar and unrestrained, entering first without any politeness.

But as soon as she entered, she exclaimed.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingya looked shocked, pointing at the house and asking: "Sister, did your house get robbed?"

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"That shouldn't be possible. This whole area is a wealthy villa district. Who would dare steal here?"

As Xu Qingya spoke, she didn't notice that Xu Qingzhu behind her had already changed expression.

Liang Shi only needed to peek inside to immediately understand what had happened.

The mess from that day hadn't been cleaned up yet.

The first floor was full of remnants from the party.

Left for several days, the smell had turned rancid.

It was like an uncleaned crime scene.

Liang Shi's expression changed slightly. She coughed lightly, "It wasn't thieves. I... had a party with friends that day, and then your sister and I went out. No one was home to clean up."

This blame fell squarely on her shoulders.

"Where are your servants?" Xu Qingya asked. "Does cleaning the house require the master's instruction? Such clueless servants should be fired immediately. Do you want to keep them for the New Year? Or..."

Xu Qingya paused. "When you got married, did you not hire any servants? Has my sister been cleaning this huge villa all by herself?"

Liang Shi: "....."

At this moment, she was willing to call Xu Qingya Sherlock Ya.

"How could that be?" Liang Shi denied with a stiff smile. "If I wouldn't do it myself, how could I let your sister do it?"

Xu Qingya breathed a sigh of relief. "Right, my sister looks pretty, but she's actually just a decorative vase¹. She doesn't do anything at home. From childhood, her only advantages were good grades and being pretty. You knew this when you married her, right? If you made her clean, I'm afraid none of your precious porcelain would survive."

Liang Shi: ".....?"

She looked toward Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu lowered her head at the right moment, not even making eye contact with her, but said irritably: "Enough, you talk too much. If you still have energy, why don't you clean?"

"Sister Liang Shi's house has servants," Xu Qingya put her hands in her pockets. "I can't do it either."

At this moment, Liang Shi seemed to somewhat understand why Xu Qingya had expressed such surprise when she said Xu Qingzhu was gentle.

It turned out the original owner had never truly understood Xu Qingzhu.

When Xu Qingzhu first married in, her submissive behavior was only because she felt guilty.

Unable to give money or her body, she forced herself to do many things she actually didn't know how to do.

It was hard to imagine how a pampered young lady could learn to do these things in such a short time.

She must have paid a heavy price.

When Liang Shi first learned to do housework, she often got bumps and bruises.

This probably also explained why Xu Qingzhu could bandage wounds so skillfully.

She must have gotten injured frequently, becoming skilled through experience.

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu with somewhat complex eyes, while Xu Qingzhu avoided her sympathetic gaze.

Liang Shi sighed inwardly and said softly: "No need, I'll have someone come clean now."

When she called the housekeeper, her heart was anxious, truly afraid the housekeeper would say the original owner had dismissed all the servants.

But fortunately, the original owner wasn't that heartless.

Some servants still lived in the small two-story building behind the villa. The housekeeper quickly brought people over to clean.

Liang Shi and the Xu sisters waited outside for a while.

Xu Qingya kept her head down playing on her phone, not communicating with them at all.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu frowned deeply, worried and preoccupied, thinking about her family's affairs.

Liang Shi just stood there, and seeing nothing else to do, started playing Snake.

The snake's body nimbly dodged around the screen. She didn't put much thought into playing, just using it to let her mind relax a bit.

The servants worked very efficiently. In less than half an hour, they had the house looking brand new. The housekeeper approached and bowed, asking: "Miss, do you need a meal?"

Liang Shi put away her phone and nodded. "Yes, make some home-style dishes, as quickly as possible."

The housekeeper listened to the instructions and called people to busy themselves in the kitchen.

They were all professionally trained, moving very quietly. You could barely hear them from the living room.

Liang Shi stood in the living room, waiting for Xu Qingzhu to assign rooms.

Originally they had agreed on the road to live separately, but given the current situation, that was no longer possible.

If the two of them were to live upstairs in the master bedroom, where would Xu Qingya stay?

"You stay downstairs, in that room," Xu Qingzhu pointed to the second room on the right. "Pack your things and come out to eat."

Xu Qingya had no objections. "Okay."

After speaking, Xu Qingzhu turned and headed upstairs.

She was still going back to the master bedroom. When going upstairs, she turned back and asked: "Are you coming?"

A very light inquiry, but spoken in her aloof manner with the ending slightly rising, it carried a hint of allure.

Liang Shi was dazed and pointed at her nose in disbelief. "Me?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded slightly.

Xu Qingya had already made herself comfortable on the sofa, her phone playing a dance video with very upbeat BGM. She raised her arms and waved, saying: "Don't mind me, just pretend I don't exist. This is your house, feel free, don't be polite."

Quite familiar indeed.

But what she said was quite endearing.

Liang Shi treated her like a little sister, smiling teasingly: "Then you feel free too."

Xu Qingya shrugged. "Do you see me being polite with you two?"

Liang Shi chuckled lightly. "That's good."

"Alright." Xu Qingya said as she stood up. "I'm going back to my room. If you two want to whisper sweet nothings, go back to your room too. I won't be your third wheel. You two..."

She winked ambiguously at them both. "Enjoy your couple's world."

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ Decorative vase (花瓶): A Chinese expression meaning someone who is only good-looking but useless or lacking in practical skills, similar to "trophy wife" in English.

Chapter 20-2

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The room still looked the same as before.

That day was Xu Qingzhu's heat period, and she had tossed and turned on the bed for a while, so the white sheets were wrinkled.

The entire room had a very luxurious style, even the chandelier was gilded.

The luxurious carpet was soft underfoot, in light colors. The room's decoration style was actually quite nice.

This was the only time Liang Shi approved of the original owner's taste.

After closing the door, Xu Qingzhu went to collect the bedsheets. Her movements were fairly swift, but when it came to putting on new sheets, she seemed less skilled.

Liang Shi immediately stepped forward to help.

She was someone who wasn't used to letting others interfere in her life, and had lived alone for many years.

Now suddenly having to share a room with someone else felt quite awkward.

Even though the other person was a stunningly beautiful woman.

Perhaps that's why her resistance wasn't so strong, though she felt a heavy psychological burden.

How would they sleep at night?

Most likely she'd have to sleep on the floor, right?

Liang Shi glanced at the carpet - it was barely clean enough.

But this kind of thing that people stepped on, no matter how visually clean it looked, would still have many bacteria.

Her cleanliness obsession wouldn't let her accept it.

It would be better to remove the carpet and lay out bedding.

While thinking this, she helped Xu Qingzhu finish making the bed. After finishing, Xu Qingzhu was somewhat tired and sat on one side of the bed, breathing slightly heavily.

She wore a high-necked, form-fitting black sweater. Her fair face had a faint camel-pink tint, her eyes were bright, and when she lowered her lashes, the thick eyelashes cast heavy shadows under her eyes. Her hair was casually tied into a bun with many loose strands at her forehead, but it didn't look messy at all.

Whether it was because she had too many worries or due to her personal constitution, she was very thin.

Even wearing a tight sweater while sitting, her lower abdomen showed no excess flesh.

She stepped barefoot on the soft carpet, her white toes seeming to form a natural painting with the carpet.

"Sorry," Xu Qingzhu said after recovering some strength. "I broke my word. I couldn't persuade my sister to go back. I'll be troubling you these next few days."

"Ah?" Liang Shi had been inadvertently lost in thought watching her, and when she came back to her senses, she only caught the word "troubling."

Liang Shi lowered her head, somewhat embarrassed. "What did you say?"

"Sorry." Xu Qingzhu patiently repeated herself, using her cool, clear voice that was like snow water from a glacier, yet it failed to cool Liang Shi's body temperature. "I'm troubling you. My family's situation isn't good right now, so I can only impose on you."

"Ah, it's fine," Liang Shi said. "These are all small matters, and besides... we're family. Your family is also my family."

Xu Qingzhu looked up at her.

She had just licked her lips, making them glisten as if sprinkled with glittery powder like jelly.

Liang Shi turned her face away, not daring to look anymore.

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi felt she needed to reiterate. "What I said before in the hospital room was all true."

"Mm?" Xu Qingzhu asked softly, her voice carrying a cool, clear intimacy. "Which things?"

"Those words about not hurting you anymore - I meant them all sincerely," Liang Shi said. "No matter what wrong things I did to you before, they're all in the past. I know I can't have the nerve to ask you to forgive me, after all, harm is irreversible."

"But..." Liang Shi paused, saying sincerely: "I will change. This isn't just empty words."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and suddenly smiled.

Her lips curved in just the right arc, her eyes half-closed, her fair face looking pink and tender, like cherry blossoms falling gracefully.

In that moment, Liang Shi even seemed to smell the scent of spring.

She felt like Xu Qingzhu had some kind of enchantment on her.

She immediately turned her face away.

But Xu Qingzhu said in a low voice: "I believe you."

Her ending tone still rose upward, like a small feather, specifically tickling people's soft spots.

"But... sorry still needs to be said," Xu Qingzhu stood up. "It's politeness."

"Alright," Liang Shi breathed a slight sigh of relief. "I just wanted to make it clear that from now on, this is your home. You can arrange things as you wish without needing to ask my opinion. Of course... if..."

She coughed lightly. "If you're in a good mood, you could occasionally listen to my opinion too."

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a moment, then laughed softly.

"I'll try my best," Xu Qingzhu said. "The food should be about ready. Let's go downstairs to eat."

"Wait." Liang Shi stopped her.

"What's wrong?"

Liang Shi stared at the carpet and asked: "Do we have new carpet? Or could we remove the carpet?"

She really couldn't stand sleeping on a carpet full of bacteria.

"We do have some," Xu Qingzhu said. "Let's change it after we eat."

"Okay." Liang Shi readily agreed.

She reached out to open the door. Xu Qingzhu was right behind her, and moved slightly forward, once again getting extremely close to her.

Afraid of being overheard, Xu Qingzhu lowered her voice and said: "You sleep on the bed tonight."

Liang Shi: ".....?"